

« Need to sustain the winning mentality at business end of tournaments »

MASSIMO COSTANTINI

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An interaction with Massimo Costantini, the Italian coach who has returned to lead the national table tennis team for the third time (2009–10, 2016–18, and 2024–present), brings to mind the ancient Japanese proverb: “Better than a thousand days of diligent study is one day with a great teacher.”

At 66, he has a remarkable ability to make anyone feel at home with his warm and generous hospitality. When he speaks, it’s from the heart, and his eyes sparkle with genuine emotion as he expresses his belief that India has the potential to break into the top four in global table tennis. In an interview with *Sportstar*, Costantini discusses a variety of topics, including the approach to developing the next generation of talent, the preparations for Los Angeles 2028, and 10-time national champion Achantha Sharath Kamal’s farewell Olympics.

What has returning to India been like thus far?

It’s been good so far. I joined in May, but even before that, I was keeping an eye on the players’ performances globally. I was already prepared with a plan for how to work with them.

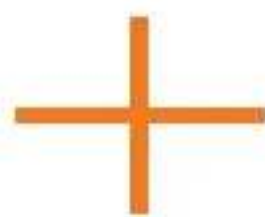
At the [Paris] Olympics, we saw a good performance, especially in the team event. The men were not very lucky with the draw. But they played very well (against China).

It was the first time India competed in the team event. The women did well to beat Romania, one of the top countries, in the

pre-quarterfinals. These good results make me very optimistic about a bright future for Indian table tennis.

Is it time to lounge for a while before proceeding, or does the grind for the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028 start now?

The Olympic cycle is a slow process. We have time in the next two years to create a better and stronger internal system. We will be stressing a little bit more on their international performances. In the meantime, we can achieve a better winning mentality. And that mentality can



My core philosophy has changed over the years. Earlier, I used to think I was the key person. Now, I say that the player is the key person.